

Chapter 7_1 - Wrist

The expression on Chu Qingqiu's face was very complex. She stood with her hands behind her back, allowing Ning Fuyi to cling to her and touch her everywhere, her front garments becoming wet and disheveled, saying nothing. The other people present didn't dare to breathe loudly either, and no one spoke.

After a long time, Ning Fuyi's strength finally exhausted. Her arms that were wrapped around Chu Qingqiu gradually loosened, her knees went soft, and she fell backward.

Just when everyone thought Chu Qingqiu would be angry, she gently reached out her hand instead, effortlessly catching the young woman's waist from behind, receiving her soft body in her arms.

The movement was as if she were holding a treasure, careful and gentle.

Several elders saw this scene and hurriedly lowered their heads, not daring to look further. They thought to themselves that perhaps their eyes were playing tricks on them, or perhaps the Divine Venerable¹ was thinking of the sect master, which was why she showed mercy.

After an unknown amount of time passed, Chu Qingqiu finally spoke, her voice low and indifferent.

"Take her back," she said.

Ning Fuyi didn't dream again. The fatigue of her body completely overwhelmed her. After she fainted, Ning Changfeng disappeared from before her eyes, leaving only pitch-black darkness where she couldn't see her hand in front of her face.

She remained in this darkness for a very long time, until annoying noise reached her ears. Only then did she reluctantly wake up.

"Ning Fuyi, if you continue sleeping, I'll force this medicine down your throat!" A woman's voice assaulted her ears, making her head ache with the noise. Ning Fuyi frowned and clicked her tongue in annoyance before opening her eyes.

The first thing she saw was a bed canopy hung with crystal pendants. This bed was unacceptably luxurious to Ning Fuyi - golden silk quilts and heavenly silkworm pillows, with calming incense placed at the head and foot of the bed, making her unable to help but sneeze.

She vigilantly turned over and sat up. Before her appeared a tall woman dressed in lake-blue brocade, holding a bowl of steaming hot medicinal soup in her hands, glaring at her with angry eyebrows and fierce eyes.

Qiu Yi? Ning Fuyi hadn't expected to see her upon waking. Momentarily surprised, she wordlessly stared at her as she heavily set down the soup bowl.

"The food is on the table. If you want to eat, get it yourself." Qiu Yi seemed quite resentful about being assigned to take care of Ning Fuyi, stomping her feet loudly as she walked.

Ning Fuyi was somewhat confused. She was just about to say that this king had been fasting for a hundred years and needed no food, when she heard a long series of rumbling sounds from her stomach.

...

Oh right, she had been reborn. She had almost forgotten that in her sleep.

"Where is my mother?" Ning Fuyi first thought of Ning Changfeng, so she asked.

"You've been sleeping for two days already. Sect Master Condensing Heaven² has naturally already been reborn. I heard she was buried at Cloud Ascension Peak³. What, do you want to go see?" Although Qiu Yi didn't speak kindly in any sentence, she still answered while crossing her arms.

"No need." Ning Fuyi shook her head. Once someone was gone, what remained was merely a body shell.

"Where is this place?" Ning Fuyi asked while raising her head to look around. She saw that the interior decoration was very unfamiliar - it didn't look like a place for cultivation, but rather like a human palace, everywhere revealing luxurious extravagance.

However, as soon as she asked the question, she already had the answer in her heart. This should be Purple Sunset Peak, Chu Qingqiu's territory. She didn't know what Chu Qingqiu's intentions were in actually bringing her back here.

"Can't you tell? This is naturally this young lady's boudoir." Qiu Yi was sharp-tongued. She disdainfully looked Ning Fuyi up and down several times, then said angrily, "If it weren't for the master's orders being inviolable, just your two acts of disrespecting the master would be enough for me to chop you down ten times!"

"Two times?" Ning Fuyi raised an eyebrow. What had happened before she fell asleep? She only remembered protecting Ning Changfeng's soul, seeing her mother's spirit for the last time, then losing consciousness.

"You still have the face to ask!" Qiu Yi's face turned red as she spoke, whether from shame or rage. "Many disciples saw it - they said you hugged the master and wouldn't let go. It's fortunate that the master is kind-hearted, otherwise..."

Qiu Yi waved the curved blade in her hand.

Hugging Chu Qingqiu? Ning Fuyi's face darkened. She only remembered not wanting to let Ning Changfeng leave. Could it be that the person she was hugging at that time wasn't her mother in the illusion, but Chu Qingqiu?

Thinking this, she couldn't hold the soup bowl anymore and set it down on the bedside table with a thud.

This time she had lost face in front of her enemy. She cursed angrily in her heart. What she couldn't tolerate most in her previous life was making a fool of herself in front of Chu Qingqiu. As a result, she had made mistakes twice in a row right after being reborn.

Forget it, forget it. The saying goes "endure hardships to accomplish great things, bear humiliation to carry heavy burdens." She, the great Ning Fuyi, the number one Demon King of the Four Seas and Eight Wastelands⁴, had only lost a little face - what was there to fear!

After comforting herself, she steadied her spirit and looked up as if nothing had happened.

"Since you're awake now, this young lady still has important matters to attend to and no time to deal with you. After you finish eating, quickly get out of Purple Sunset Peak!" Qiu Yi said with her chin raised, turning to leave.

"Wait a moment." Ning Fuyi called out to stop her, sitting in place and pointing toward the food box on the table, curling her lips in a smile. "I'm weak and can't reach it."

Hearing this, Qiu Yi was so angry she almost jumped up: "Ning Fuyi, you!"

Ning Fuyi tilted her head slightly with an innocent expression: "Didn't you say the master's orders are inviolable?"

Qiu Yi clenched her fists and stood in place for quite a while before finally gritting her teeth tightly, striding to the table to grab the food box, then stomping back to the bed and forcefully shoving it into Ning Fuyi's arms.

"Eat quickly, and get lost after you finish!" After saying this, she turned her head and disappeared with a "pop" sound.

No matter which lifetime, her temper was always this bad. Ning Fuyi chuckled scornfully, too lazy to tease her further. She picked up the medicinal soup and sniffed it near her nose.

It was all high-quality spiritual medicine, no poison. She tilted her head back and drank it all, then picked up the food box, took out the food inside, and slowly filled her stomach.

No matter when, the body was always the foundation.

After eating and drinking her fill, she didn't rush to leave. Instead, she sat cross-legged on the bed, hands folded, summoning the little immortal power within her body. She sent it along her meridians to investigate. She still remembered that surge of power that had burst from within her body yesterday - that power she had never felt before. It seemed very unfamiliar, but when it filled her body for that instant, it also seemed to merge with her, inseparable.

Although both immortal cultivation and demonic cultivation emphasized talent and opportunities, any opportunity was meant to teach you how to fish. Something that suddenly appeared within the body like this - she had lived for a thousand years and never heard of such a thing.

However, after the immortal power circulated through her body for a full cycle, that power from yesterday seemed to have evaporated, leaving no trace.

Could it really be that she had misunderstood? Ning Fuyi was very puzzled, but could only set it aside for now and get dressed to go down.

However, she wasn't too disappointed. After all, Ning Fuyi knew her own capabilities. She had long known the fact that she could be described as waste when it came to cultivation. Having cultivated to this age and still only being at the Initial Realm⁵, immortal techniques that others could learn in a day would take her a month to learn only seventy to eighty percent, and she had suffered no little bullying and mockery.

It wasn't until later when her relatives and friends all died tragically and she was forced into demonization that her power began to advance by leaps and bounds.

So Ning Fuyi currently had no intention of achieving anything in immortal cultivation. She was inherently of the extreme yin meridian⁶, a person destined for dark evil, unable to be a good person from birth.

The world said demons were detestable, so she would deliberately cultivate this demonic path.

After pondering, Ning Fuyi pushed open the door and strode out, preparing to first leave Purple Sunset Peak and return to Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate to make further plans.

Purple Sunset Peak was only a few mountains away from Cloud Ascension Mountain, but it was a dangerous peak where no birds flew and no paths existed for people. This peak extended deep into the clouds, a place mortals could not climb. Usually, aside from Chu Qingqiu and Qiu Yi, there was no one else, so it appeared quite desolate.

Perhaps due to the barrier, there wasn't even an insect on the road. Everywhere were scattered rocks, with only the occasional green leaf sprouting from rock crevices - already precious life on this mountain.

As Ning Fuyi walked unsteadily, one step deep and one step shallow, she sighed in her heart. She somewhat admired that Qiu Yi could follow Chu Qingqiu and remain in this godforsaken place for so long.

When she was almost down the mountain, Ning Fuyi stopped again and looked to her right. There extended a small path paved with bluestone, at the end of which was a cold stone hall - Chu Qingqiu's residence.

She hesitated for a moment, then suddenly turned around and headed toward the stone hall.

She wasn't stupid and could naturally sense the differences after this rebirth. Although she was still herself, she seemed to have been dragged into another life trajectory, where many things that had left deep impressions in her previous life had not occurred.

For example, that inexplicable marriage contract, for example, the person who saved her becoming Chu Qingqiu, and for example, she didn't need to kneel outside Chu Qingqiu's door for a night and a day, begging her to let her see her mother one last time.

Now that she finally had time to think about these things one by one, she would discover that all these differences were because of Chu Qingqiu.

Since she had come all this way today, before leaving she might as well pay a visit. Perhaps she could find some answers.

While thinking, she had already arrived outside the stone hall. This place didn't look like an immortal's residence at all, but rather like an ancient tomb burying ancient corpses. Ning Fuyi pursed her lips outside the door. Just as she was about to knock, her hand suddenly stopped in mid-air.

She suddenly remembered that Chu Qingqiu loved setting up barriers. No matter where she went, she would set one up. When Ning Fuyi was young, she had thoughtlessly intruded once and nearly had her nose burned off by the barrier. Fortunately, Ning Changfeng had quick eyes and hands, grabbing her up in time, preventing her from becoming a noseless Demon King.

Ning Fuyi touched her nose with lingering fear. Her hand lingered in place for a while, then tentatively touched the barrier's surface.

The expected burning sensation didn't appear. A water mist-like membrane slid over her skin, like a giant bubble that broke and healed again. Ning Fuyi was somewhat surprised and boldly lifted her leg to step through the barrier.

Like her whole body was immersed in cool water, then emerged dry, Ning Fuyi looked down at her perfectly intact body, somewhat surprised.

This barrier actually had no effect on her.

Inside the hall was even more desolate, with cool air flowing darkly in the atmosphere. The sunlight from outside seemed never to reach here, with only the pale light of night pearls filling the corridors.

"Divine Venerable Chu Ling?" Ning Fuyi called out loudly.

No one responded to her. Ning Fuyi felt something was strange. After hesitating for a while, she slowly moved forward.

She had come to this place with Ning Changfeng before, so she was familiar with the way. After a few steps, she navigated the winding passages and arrived outside the sleeping chamber.

However, when she reached this place, she detected something wrong. In the air that originally only carried the fragrance of gardenia flowers, a faint scent of blood suddenly drifted by.

"Chu Qingqiu?" Ning Fuyi called out softly again. Seeing that no one still responded, she furrowed her brow and stepped through the door, immediately gasping in cold air.

She saw chaos throughout the hall. The stone low table was somehow splattered with drops of blood, as if spat from someone's mouth. Several oil lamps had been knocked to the ground, their flames igniting papers on the floor, burning along the wall corners, adding some warmth to the stone hall.

And beneath the stone table, a small corner of clothing color was faintly visible.

Ning Fuyi lifted her skirt and stepped over the flames on the ground, carefully walking around to behind the stone table. She saw clearly the face of the person lying on their side there - it was none other than Chu Qingqiu.

She seemed to have endured some great torment, her dark eyebrows slightly furrowed, her face pale as death, her lips still stained with specks of blood, clearly in a weakened state, completely different from her usual self.

Ning Fuyi was stunned for a moment, staring at Chu Qingqiu for a while before raising her hand to extinguish the flames. The hall returned to its cold quietness.

She half-crouched down, her left hand slowly stroking over her arm, finally grasping that exposed pale wrist, tightening her grip, then gently pulling up. The person softly turned over and fell into her arms.

That wrist felt smooth and soft in her palm, as white as snow.

Footnotes:

¹ Divine Venerable (神尊) - A high-ranking title in Chinese cultivation novels, indicating someone who has reached near-godlike status in their cultivation journey.

² Condensing Heaven (凝天) - The name of Ning Fuyi's mother's sect.

³ Cloud Ascension Peak (云际峰) - A peak within the Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate sect.

⁴ Four Seas and Eight Wastelands (四海八荒) - An expression meaning "everywhere in the world" or "all corners of the earth."

⁵ Initial Realm (初境) - The first and lowest level of cultivation in this story's power system.

⁶ Extreme Yin Meridian (至阴之脉) - A type of spiritual constitution that naturally tends toward dark/negative energy, making the person more suited for demonic cultivation than righteous cultivation.